feet first, don't fall

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25076443.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by troubleseemstfollow

Summary

Catra has no clue how to tell her dumb idiot jock of a best friend that she loves her. Especially when that dumb idiot jock of a best friend has a crush on someone else.

Notes

hi yes this is my first attempt at writing fic in a very long time! i honestly am not sure where this is going as of right now, but it was fun to write. i hope u enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

“Stop fidgeting!”

"I’m not, I’m not!” Adora protests, and ducks away from Catra’s reach. Catra huffs in annoyance and glares at her best friend, who erupts into a fit of laughter.

It was a Friday, and the two girls are sat in Adora’s childhood bedroom on her bed, the late afternoon sun filtering in through the tiny window above Adora’s desk. Makeup in all forms-mascara tubes, eyeshadow palettes, glitter, lipstick, blush-clutter the bedsheets as Catra tries, yet again, to finish the wing of eyeliner on Adora’s left eye.

"I’m doing this for you!” Catra exclaims, waving the eyeliner in Adora’s face.

"I know, I know, and thank you, you’re just pressing too hard!” Adora complains. Catra bites back a snort of amusement.

"Fine, you do it yourself.” Catra stands up off of the bed and mock-dusts herself off, eyeliner pen still in hand. She pauses, mid dust. “Remind me where you’re going again?”

"Please stay, Catra” Adora pleads dramatically, leaning forwards on the bed so she can grab Catra’s wrist. “You know I’m no good at makeup. And I told you already, the team and I are going out for dinner to celebrate the end of the season."

"When has going out with your soccer team ever made you want to put on makeup?” Catra asks, but she sits back down on the bed, facing Adora. She uncaps the eyeliner pen, and Adora leans into her space, waiting expectantly for Catra to resume the eyeliner application. Catra’s breath hitches slightly in her throat at their sudden closeness, and she blushes slightly. Catra feels relief wash over her when Adora doesn’t notice, as her eyes were already closed.

"Well, Huntara is going to be there, obviously," Adora says, now a bit more seriously, a small blush forming across her cheeks. "And I-I don't know, I want to make an impression on her. I always thought she was, um, hot, or whatever."

Catra feels a dark wave of jealousy wash over her, but shakes it off as quickly as it came as she carefully raises the eyeliner to Adora's left eye. Careful not to touch the other girl, she draws a sharp, precise wing of eyeliner with two strokes. Finished, Catra sits back on her heels, admiring her handiwork.

"Which one is Huntara again?" Catra asks, trying to sound disinterested. She caps the eyeliner pen and begins to collect the makeup scattered over Adora's bed, intentionally avoiding the other girl's gaze, the fog of jealousy still sitting tight in her chest. Catra guesses that she hadn't shaken it off as much as she had thought.

"You know who Huntara is!" Adora playfully nudges Catra's shoulder. "Senior? Goalie? Like, 6 foot 3? Purple hair? Insane muscles? Come on, Catra."

"Well, I don't know that," Catra mumbles, shoving the products into Adora's makeup bag. "Anyways, I'm sure you've made an impression on her already. You're the first junior to ever be made captain on a Horde High sports team."

Adora must not have heard, as she had lifted the handheld mirror that was perviously sitting beside her up to her face, turning her head from side to side, looking at her eyes. "Catra, this is beautiful!" She lowers the mirror and grins at Catra. Aside from the eyeliner, Adora's lips were painted a neutral-pink, and a light sprinkling of blush and highlighter were applied to her cheeks and cheekbones respectively.

You look beautiful, Catra can't help but think. But she grins back, although a bit painfully. This time, Adora notices.

“Are you sure you don’t want to come?” Adora asks gently, placing her hand on Catra’s. Her touch feels like electricity. “Even though it is a team dinner, we can all bring a plus-one, you know.”

"No, it’s fine!” Catra exclaims, and winces internally at herself at how shrill her voice sounded. She clears her throat. “Really Adora, it’s fine. I have some physics homework to catch up on for Monday anyways.”

Adora frowns. “Are you sure? You have all weekend to work on physics.”

Catra climbs a mountain in her head before she allows herself to put her other hand over Adora’s. “I’ll be okay. Please, just go, have fun with the team.”

Adora smiles up at Catra and envelops her in one of her Classic Adora Hugs. Catra hugs her back, trying to ignore the comforting vanilla-scent of Adora’s shampoo.

Beside them on the bed, Adora’s phone buzzes twice.

"Oh!” Adora breaks the embrace, grabbing her phone hastily. “Lonnie’s here to pick me up! I’ve got to go, will you be okay to get home?”

“Adora, I literally live a block away from you,” Catra says fondly, still sat on the bed, watching the other girl throw on her red jacket and a pair of shoes. “Text me later, you idiot.”

"Bye Catra! And thanks!” Adora doesn’t look back as she runs out of her room. Catra sighs, and buries her face in her hands.

You disaster lesbian, Catra thinks miserably.

Chapter 2

The fire crackles as Catra prods at a burning log with a stick. She slumps down in one of her parent's old lawn chairs in her backyard, staring miserably at the little fire pit she had made with Adora a few summers back. The early June heat is already making her feel sweaty, and this fire she had made wasn't helping. Aside from the sound of cicadas and ember burning, she can hear Scorpia and Entrapta chattering around her. Up until now, Catra had tuned them out.

"Do you think I should dye my hair purple?" she interrupts them suddenly.

Scorpia looks up at her in surprise from her own lawn chair across the fire pit, her laptop balanced on her knees and angled in a way so that Catra could see the screen clearly. From the laptop screen, Entrapta-who was only able to join them virtually that night due to working on her latest project at home-looked at up at her, her work goggles still covering her eyes. Catra had asked Adora to join them too, but she hadn't been available. Catra missed her.

"Dye your hair purple? Why?" Scorpia asks, frowning slightly.

"Forget it," Catra huffs slightly, feeling embarrassed. "It was a stupid question." She drops the stick on the ground beside her chair and crosses her arms defensively.

"This is about Adora's post." Entrapta, always the ever-knowing, states. Her voice is a little fuzzy do to the poor internet connection in Catra's backyard.

Catra bristles. "No! I don't even know what you're talking about." That was, of course, a lie.

When Catra had woken up, the morning after Adora went out to dinner with her team, Scorpia had already texted her about Adora's latest Instagram post. Why she has Adora's post

notifications on, Catra will never know. Ignoring Scorpia's text, Catra had groggily opened up Instagram to see a photo of Adora, miraculously still wearing the makeup Catra had carefully painted on her, grinning from ear to ear. She was posed with her team outside of the restaurant. Right next to Huntara. Catra buried her head into her pillow and groaned.

"What's wrong with Adora's post? I thought she looked great," Scorpia says.

"It's not about how she looked," Catra replies roughly. Obviously, she knew Adora looked great.

"Anyways, Catra, I think purple hair would look great on you!" Entrapta exclaims. "We could form a purple-haired squad at school. You, me, and Huntara!"

"Hey, wait a minute! What about m-," Scorpia pauses, and her eyes widen. "Oh. I get it now. This is about Huntara."

"It is not!" Catra cries. "Enough about purple hair! Also, Entrapta, you're clearly biased."

"Catra," Scorpia leans in towards her, almost causing the laptop to slip off of her kness. "Do you have a *crush on Huntara?"*

"No!" Catra shouts, her hands balled into fists as she jumps to her feet. *"I have a crush on Adora!"*

Catra freezes. Scorpia stares at her in shock. Even Entrapta was was quiet. Catra exhales shakily, and gingerly sits back down on the lawn chair, laying her hands delicately on her thighs.

"I'm sorry," Catra catches her breath, looking down. "I've never admitted that to anyone." She pauses, before continuing quietly, "Not even myself. We've just known each other for so long, and-"

Before Catra could look up, Scorpia crushes her into a hug. Catra pretends to struggle for a few heartbeats, but gives in and hugs

her friend back. Scorpia gives good hugs. But not as good as Adora.

“Wildcat! I’m so happy for you!” Scorpia almost sobs. “This is so exciting! You and Adora are perfect for each other. I can’t wait for you to start dating and to get married and-’

“Hey! I’m down here!” Entrapta calls from where the laptop, in Scorpia’s rush, has been dropped dangerously close to the fire. Catra reaches out with her foot and nudges it away from the flames.

“Woah, calm down,” Catra says hurriedly, pushing Scorpia away slightly. “She doesn’t even know. And besides,” Catra tries to hide the bitter tone in her voice, “Adora likes Huntara. She told me so herself. I don’t want to get in the way of her happiness.”

“Don’t worry, Wildcat,” Scorpia promises, lifting up the laptop so Entrapta was level with the rest of them, “You’ll be okay. We’ll figure something out, I promise.”

“We promise! Right, Darla?” Entrapta angles her own camera over to the little model spaceship she must have been working on for Catra to see.

“Thanks, guys.” Catra sighs. She's going to need all the help she can get.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Dating.

According to Adora, she and Huntara may start dating.

It was Monday morning, a weekend having past since Adora went out for dinner with the team. A weekend since the Instagram post, and Catra admitting her feelings for her best friend. And exactly 12 hours had passed since Catra lay in her bed wallowing in her feelings, neglecting to do her physics homework, and ignoring Adora's texts.

Now, at 7:15 in the morning on a Monday, while getting into the passenger seat of Adora's busted, hand-me-down red Sedan she had received for her 16th birthday, Catra had to hear the girl she had a crush on tell her that she and Huntara may start dating. Catra's day couldn't have started any better.

Pulling out of Catra's driveway, Adora says, "Huntara and I really hit it off that night. I mean, we always liked each other I guess, being on the team and all, but we really started talking."

"Is that so?" Catra asks tiredly, fiddling with one of her backpack straps. Her chest feels tight.

"Yes! We talked all weekend, and she eventually asked me out," Adora grins excitedly as the car shudders down Catra's street. Catra glares at Adora when she makes a rolling stop at the end of Eternia Boulevard, but Adora just shrugs sheepishly. Despite not bothering to get her license until months after her best friend, Catra had always been the better driver. She winces slightly as Adora aggressively pulls onto the main road.

Adora babbles on, barely taking a break between words. “She’s just so strong and smart and she’s great at keeping conversation and she told me how much she admired me for being the first junior team captain at school-”

“So yes? You’re dating?” Catra cuts in.

Adora looks over at her and blinks. “Well, not yet. I told you, we still have to go on that date first. Huntara is taking me to Red Lobster.”

Catra smiles tightly at her friend, trying her hardest to be supportive, but can’t help but think that the 10 minute drive to Horde High School (with the usual stop at a Starbucks drive through for iced coffee) was going to feel longer than usual. She’s really going to need that caffeine.

“Anyways,” Adora changes the subject, finally turning back to look at the road. She seems to have read Catra’s thoughts as she continues, “I have to get to school early. I’m meeting with Coach and the VP.”

“What? Early?” Catra asks in surprise. “What about Starbucks?”

“I’m sorry Catra. I’m going to have to take a rain check on that one,” Adora apologizes. She ignores the blaring of a car horn from behind her when she failed to signal her lane change, cutting off the driver from behind them.

Catra hides her disappointment. She tries again, “What’s the meeting about?”

Adora waves her hand nonchalantly. “Something about some summer volunteer opportunity at a little kid soccer league. Nothing too stressful.”

Catra studies Adora’s face. Something felt off. Adora looks over at her friend in the passenger seat, and laughs.

“Stop looking so grouchy about missing your iced coffee,” she teases, reaching over to nudge Catra’s shoulder. Almost on reflex, Catra flinches away from her. Adora pulls her hand back as if she was burned, a look of hurt flashing over her face.

“Keep both hands on the wheel,” Catra chides, praying that her cover up is convincing enough. Adora grins, but her smile doesn’t reach her eyes as she places both hands back on 10 and 2.

The rest of the car ride to school is quiet, aside from the music playing softly from the car’s radio. When they arrive at Horde High, Catra and Adora find a parking spot easily. Catra can’t help but fondly watch as Adora struggles to align her car within the lines of the parking space, swearing along the way. They finally park, and both hop out of the car, backpacks in tow, as Adora locks it.

“So, I’ll see you later?” Catra asks Adora hopefully as they make their way towards the school entrance.

Adora bites her lip, and looks over at Catra. “Actually, I have to stay after school. For a track thing. I’m sorry.”

Once again, Catra hides her disappointment. It’s something she’s starting to get really good at lately.

“I’ll text you!” Adora promises, and she reached down to squeeze Catra’s hand with her own. Catra feels her mouth dry. Adora’s hands, as usual, are big and warm and calloused.

“Promise?” Catra rasps.

“I promise.” Adora smiles at her friend. Then, her eyes widen. “Oh! I’m late. I’ve got to go.” Before Catra could tease her for always being late and on the run, Adora squeezes Catra into a brief hug. “Bye, Catra.”

Catra watches as her friend tears into the building, leaving her standing alone in the entrance. Catra suddenly feels very cold now that Adora was no longer touching her.

Shaking her head, Catra pulls out her phone from her jeans pocket, and dials a number. She presses the phone to her ear, waiting patiently for the other end to pick up.

“Hello?” Scorpia picks up the phone after three rings.

“Scorpia?” Catra asks, then clears her throat when she realizes how raspy her voice still sounds. “Scorpia, are you on your way?”

“Just leaving the house, Wildcat,” Scorpia replies cheerfully. “What’s up?”

Catra runs her free hand through her hair tiredly. “Would you mind stopping by a Starbucks to grab me an iced coffee on the way here?”

“Of course!” Scorpia says, then pauses. “Are you alright, Catra?”

Catra forces a laugh. “I’m fine. Thanks Scorpia. I owe you one.”

Catra hangs up and leans back against the school wall, already feeling drained. She can still feel the ghost of Adora’s hand in her own.

Chapter End Notes

PLEASE DO NOT DRIVE LIKE ADORA!!!

Chapter 4

Catra yelps and scrambles away from the pool edge, trying her best not to get wet. Scorpia had just cannonballed into the water, sending a huge wave heading straight in Catra's direction. She winces when she feels the mist touch her skin, but has otherwise remained dry.

It was during fourth period when Scorpia had suggested to Catra and Entrapta that they should head over to her place for a swim in the pool to, according to Scorpia, "relax and unwind". Catra had scoffed at that. She had never relaxed a day in her life, but she obliged, grateful to spend these hot days with her friends. But now, as she struggles away from the water, she doesn't feel as grateful.

Scorpia resurfaces, sending ripples throughout the pool. "Catra! The water is beautiful! Please come in," she pleads, dog-paddling over to where Catra was standing uncomfortably by the lawn chairs.

"I'm okay up here, thanks," Catra says, rubbing her forearm. Despite the heat, nothing could ever make Catra go into the water. She just can't understand why people would want to try and not drown for fun.

Days had past since Adora had skipped out on their usual morning iced coffee run. Catra had felt hurt, stung, by that rejection, but soon shook it off. She had other things to worry about! Projects to finish, exams coming up, summer about to start. No need to worry about a stupid crush. Catra is going to be just fine.

(Even though she felt like she was starting to lead a double life; one day seeing Adora, the next Scorpia and Entrapta, then back to Adora. Again, Catra was going to be just fine.)

"Catra, Scorpia, look!" Catra turns her head to see Entrapta, waist deep in the shallow end, drop in one of her many home-made

mini submarines into the water. Catra can't help but marvel at the little submarine as it dives down into the deep end, controlled by a remote in Entrapta's hands. Catra and Scorpia give her a thumbs up.

"Come on, Wildcat!" Scorpia almost whines, turning back to look at Catra. "It's no fun if you don't come in. Just because your name is Catra doesnt mean you have to hate the water."

Catra bristles. "I would rather fail all of my exams than get wet, thanks. Also, cool name joke. I've definitely never heard that one before."

Scorpia holds both of her hands up. "Okay, okay, I surrender. I just think that since I always invite you over to swim at the pool, you should really-"

"I'm here! Sorry I'm late!" comes a voice. Catra recognizes that voice immediately.

Catra whips her head around to see Adora, of all people, step into Scorpia's backyard through the wooden gate, flashing her usual Adora grin. She's wearing a Hawaiian shirt, khaki shorts, and flip flops, and carries a beach bag. Adora visibly perks up when she sees Catra. She looks stupid and she looks beautiful.

"Adora! Over here!" Scorpia waves her over, and Adora, now barefoot, flip flops discarded on the grass, pads over to the pool's edge. Catra watches her, trying to appear unbothered. She knows she's failing by the tell-tale sign of heat rushing to her cheeks.

"I'm glad you could come!" beans Scorpia. She turns to Catra and explains, "I invited Adora over to the pool yesterday, at wrestling practice. Entrapta was there also." At the sound of her name, Entrapta looks up briefly, then resumes her tinkering.

Catra was stunned. She didn't even know that Scorpia and Entrapta and Adora talked that much without her. Even if Scorpia and Adora were on the wrestling team together.

“Y-you didn’t tell me!” Catra can’t help but splutter. She looks over at Adora. “Neither of you did!”

Adora only shrugs. “I’m here now.”

Catra felt hurt. She would think that her best friend would tell her these things.

“It’s hot.” Adora observes, and before Catra could blink, shucks off her Hawaiian shirt. Underneath, she’s wearing a red one piece. Catra looks away, blushing slightly, and the chides herself internally. She’s known Adora for over 10 years! This is not new!

“How’s the temperature, Entrapta?” Adora, khakis now abandoned, calls over. Entrapta replies with a single thumbs up, her nose buried in her remote as she fiddles with the switches. The submarine was nowhere to be seen in the pool.

Adora tightens her ponytail. “That’s always a good sign.” Then, without warning, she puts her hands together and dives. Even Adora’s dives are perfect.

“Hey, wait!” Catra screeches, jumping back again but this time, not missing the splash. The front of her shirt and shorts are soaked. She feels like a wet towel. From beside her in the pool, Scorpia was completely drenched, laughing.

Adora’s head breaks the water and Catra almost forgets about how much she hates being wet. The water droplets in Adora’s hair sparkles, and the blue of the water brings out Adora’s eyes.

“Good dive, Adora!” Entrapta calls, wading over towards them from the shallow end, remote now abandoned at the pool’s edge. Scorpia cheers in agreement.

Catra can’t bring herself to look at Adora. She can’t believe Scorpia ambushed her like this. Especially when she knew how Catra felt about Adora. Catra tries to feel resentful, but ultimately fails when she sneaks a glance and sees Adora laughing at a joke Entrapta had just told her. Catra decides to shake it off.

After a few hours of what Catra perceived as aimless splashing around, Entrapta, Adora, and Scorpia are floating around lazily on Scorpia's inflatable pool floaters. Catra choses to doze on the poolside lawn chairs. The temperature has gone from an unbearable blaze to a comfortable warmth as the afternoon ticks away. Scorpia's moms had checked on them twice to bring them fruit and water.

"Hey Adora, how are you and Huntara doing?" Scorpia asks conversationally from her flamingo floater. Catra groans internally.

Adora beams from where she was sitting on an inflatable chair. "We're doing well! We're going on that date soon. We aren't girlfriends yet, obviously, but I like where we're headed."

"Catra said she wanted to dye her hair purple too, just like Huntara and I." Entrapta mentions from where she was clinging on to a pool noodle, next to Adora. Adora straightens up and looks over at Catra, eyebrows raised.

Catra rushes for a cover up. "I was joking! I was, um, just thinking about doing something with my hair. I wasn't being serious."

Adora looks thoughtful. "You want to do something with your hair? Like what?"

"Get an undercut!" Scorpia exclaims.

"Bangs!" suggests Entrapta.

"Shave it off!" Scorpia cries.

Catra's hand goes to the back of her head. "Actually, I have always wanted to get an undercut. My hair gets so thick in the summer."

"You know what this means!" Adora slips off of her pool floater, grabs the end of Entrapta's pool noodle pulling her with it, and

swims over to Catra, eyes gleaming. Scorpia has already crawled out of the pool and was running into her house.

“What are you doing,” Catra says cautiously as Entrapta and Adora loom over her. Catra hears the bang of Scorpia’s back door, signalling that she had already returned. Entrapta and Adora grin in response.

When Catra and Adora and Entrapta leave Scorpia’s house, Catra ties her long hair up in a ponytail. She touches her new undercut for what feels like the hundredth time in the past 10 minutes she’s had it. Scorpia, Adora, and Scorpia’s moms had watched as Entrapta carefully shaved the undercut. At first, Catra wasn’t too sure, but now it felt good. It felt new and different.

“Do you like it?” Adora asks as they walk to her car. Catra had taken the bus with Scorpia and Entrapta to get to Scorpia’s house from school, but now Adora was giving her and Entrapta a ride home.

“I love it.” Catra says. She loves it. She also loves how the corners of Adora’s eyes crinkle when she smiles. But of course, she’ll never tell Adora that.

Chapter 5

Adora and Huntara are the talk of the town.

Technically, the talk of Horde High School. The rumour mill was churning, and whispers of them finally going official have made their way onto all of Catra's social medias and into her homeroom. It's all anyone seems to be talking about.

"I bet Huntara is going to ask Adora to the prom," Catra overhears Mantenna say from the desk behind her.

"I heard that Huntara took her to a 5-star restaurant for their second date," she hears Rattlor reply.

"Leech told me that Huntara got her a promise ring already."

"Isn't that a bit soon?"

"I don't know. I don't think so. They are lesbians, after all."

Catra feels slightly sick. She thinks about how grateful she is that she took the city bus to school today, instead of riding with Adora. At least that way, she was guaranteed an iced coffee.

"Catra? Are you okay? You look a little green," Kyle, a scrawny blond boy who sits next to Catra in homeroom, asks her cautiously. Catra shoots him a glare, and Kyle flinches. Catra decides that she has had enough of blondes for today.

Ignoring Kyle, Catra buries her face in her hands. She refuses to resurface until the bell rings, signalling the beginning of class.

Catra zones out throughout the entire lesson. Not that calculus was anything interesting first thing in the morning anyways. Catra figures she's going to have to spend the entire school day dodging questions about Adora, trying her best to ignore gossip, and staying as under the radar as best as she can. Every mention of her best friend feels like ice in her heart.

Not that Adora's been much of a best friend lately, Catra reminds hersef. Not with her being too busy for Catra and skipping out on Starbucks runs. The last time she properly hung out with Adora was at Scorpia's pool, a week ago. Which Adora hadn't even told her she was going to be at.

Catra tries not to feel bitter.

First and second period tick by, and the lunch bell rings. Catra trudges miserably to her and Scorpia and Entrapta's usual table in the cafeteria. They greet her, Scorpia with her usual friendly grin and Entrapta acknowledging her with a nod of the head before resuming whatever new project she was currently working on. Catra sits down with her unappealing tray of cafeteria food-sludge, more accurately-and picks miserably at the contents. It was brown ration bars today, Catra's least favourite. She wrinkles her nose with disgust, and pushes the tray away.
Catra's ears pricked slightly as she tries to tune in on Scorpia and Entrapta's conversation.

"So, as I was saying," Scorpia says, "We can all study at my place this Wednesday. My moms will be working late that day, so it'll be nice and quiet for us to prepare for exams next week. I swear, that math final is going to be the end of me." Scorpia shudders. Entrapta murmurs in sympathy. Catra zones out again.

It takes several seconds for Catra to realize Scorpia was calling her name.

"What?" Catra's head snaps up. Scorpia stares at her.

"I said what do you think?"

"About what?"

Scorpia, being the saint that she is, doesn't huff with annoyance, which is what anyone else would do. Instead, she smiles patiently. "Are you coming over on Wednesday to study with Entrapta and I?"

“I don’t know, I guess.” Catra says unenthusiastically.

“Great!” Scorpia grins, clapping her hands together.

Catra can’t help herself, before she adds, “I hope you’re not inviting Adora over to study too.”

Scorpia frowns, blinking at her. “What?”

Catra feels herself flush hot with annoyance. It comes over her, like a wave. “What was that about anyways, inviting Adora over last week to the pool without telling me?” she demands.

Scorpia stares at her. Even Entrapta pauses whatever she was writing down in her notebook to look up at Catra.

“What do you mean? Adora’s my friend. She’s your friend. It was hot outside,” Scorpia says.

Catra scoffs, leaning back in her chair and crossing her arms. “Scorpia, I know what you’re trying to do. And it’s not working.”

Scorpia continues to stare at Catra in confusion. “What are you talking about? I wasn’t trying to do anything!”

Catra looks around the cafeteria quickly, checking to see if there is anyone within earshoot. Deciding the coast is clear, Catra leans across the table towards Scorpia and hisses, “You know how I feel about her! I can’t believe you did that to me.”

Scorpia’s face crumbles, and Entrapta butts in, “Hey now Catra, Scorpia didn’t mean any harm. She just thought it would be a nice gesture to invite Adora over. She wasn’t trying to incite anything.”

“I just thought that, since Adora’s your friend, and she’s my friend, it would be nice to invite her over,” Scorpia sniffles. “I’m so sorry Catra. I didn’t even think. I wasn’t trying to put you in an awkward position. But I did, didn’t I? I’m so sorry.”

Catra, for what feels like the millionth time today, buries her face in her hands. She feels too tired for conflict. “Scorpia, I know, it’s just-it’s okay. I guess it’s complicated. I’m sorry. It’s just-Adora’s with Huntara now, and exams are coming up, and everything is hard.” She takes a deep breath. “I’m sorry for snapping at you.”

A pause.

Catra peeks through her fingers, and catches Scorpia and Entrapta exchanging a glance. She drops her hands down onto the table. “What?”

“Catra,” Scorpia begins, still sniffling slightly, “It’s okay to be jealous. It’s a normal human emotion.”

“I am not jealous,” Catra scoffs.

Both Entrapta and Scorpia stare pointedly at Catra.

“I am not! Stop looking at me like that!”

.

When Catra arrives at home, she crashes on top of her bed. She feels exhausted. Lunch with Scorpia and Entrapta definitely didn’t go as planned, and Catra spent the entirety of fourth period avoiding some Adora-obsessed theatre kid who wanted to know everything about Adora and Huntara’s relationship. Horde High’s obsession with their star student athletes never failed to make Catra feel weird. She thought that, with exams happening next week, the school would have better things to worry about.

She begins to close her eyes, ready for a well-deserved nap, when her phone buzzes from beside her.

Groaning, Catra grabs her phone and holds it over her face, squinting as the screen comes into focus. It’s a text from Adora.

“Can’t you just leave me alone?” Catra groans. Nevertheless, she unlocks her phone and opens up the chat.

“Huntara and I are not together,” the text from Adora reads.

Catra drops her phone.

Chapter 6

"Shit!" Catra hisses, wincing as her phone hits her face. Her nose stings from where the corner made contact. That was definitely going to leave a bruise later.

She scrambles to pick up her phone, which has fallen down beside her, and stares at the text message from Adora.

Huntara and I are not together.

Clear as mud.

Catra feels her ears ring. Why was Adora telling her this? Is it true? What's going on?

Catra, fingers shaking, types out a simple "???" and hits Send. Immediately, the three bubbles appear in the bottom left corner of the chat, telling Catra that Adora was about to respond. Catra begins to tremble.

"Come over," the text message reads simply. So Catra does.

.

"Hi!" Adora smiles warmly as she opens the door to Catra, sweating and panting before her. Catra had ran all the way down to Adora's house, ignoring the puzzled looks from her father on the way out. She had to see Adora.

How is she so calm? Catra wonders as her friend closes the door behind them. Adora had revealed the biggest social bomb that could destroy Horde High with just 25 characters.

"Why do you have a red mark on your nose?" Adora asks.

"Dropped my phone," Catra explains hastily. She ignores the laughter in Adora's eyes. "Adora, what's going on?"

Adora has the decency to look slightly tired. "Come up to my room," she says, grabbing Catra's wrist and pulling her to the stairs. Catra's skin burns where Adora is touching her.

"Okay, so, this is a long story," Adora begins once the two of them were in her room, sitting on Adora's bed. Despite the urgency of the situation, just being close to Adora and in Adora's room felt so familiar, and calms Catra down.

Catra snorts. "Adora, you have the entire school gossiping about your love life. And then you go and tell me that you're not dating and you're not going going to the prom and you're not getting married? What happened?"

"What?" Adora tilts her head in confusion. "What are you talking about? Who said anything about prom? Marriage? It was just two dates."

Catra blushes furiously. "Never mind. Anyways. Tell me what happened."

Adora shrugs. "Huntara and I hit it off at the team dinner. We started to talk more after, and she eventually asked me out. We went out on the date, then a second. Turns out we work better as friends. We're still friends. It was mutual. End of story."

Catra's jaw drops. She was expecting some story about how Huntara had cruelly broken Adora's heart, leaving Catra to pick up the pieces. Catra had all but prepared to kill Huntara. But this?

"End of story?" Catra all but screams. "Adora, you said it was a long story,"

Adora crosses her arms in mock defensiveness. "Long enough to me!"

"Then why is the entire school going on and on about you and Huntara?" Catra demands.

"I don't know, I think someone took a picture of us leaving Red Lobster and posted it," Adora says, shrugging.

"A picture? What are you, a celebrity?"

Adora shrugs again. She pauses, then continues, "Also, Double Trouble happened to be our server. You know they live for gossip."

"So," Catra says slowly. "This whole mess is because Double Trouble couldn't keep their mouth shut."

"Yeah, basically."

Catra flops down on Adora's bed in defeat. "You're impossible." A strand of her hair falls in her face, and Catra tries weakly to blow it away with no success.

Adora smiles and lays down next to Catra. Carefully, as if on instinct, Adora brushes the hair out of Catra's face with one hand. The act feels so gentle and kind and intimate. Catra freezes immediately, staring up at the other girl, her heart in her throat and her face burning.

Noticing Catra's reaction, Adora awkwardly leans away, retracting her hand and breaks eye contact. She blushes slightly.

Catra feels like she could cry. What she would give to have Adora touching her face like that again.

The silence and awkwardness in the air between the two girls is thick.

"We didn't even kiss, you know." Adora says softly after a beat, breaking the silence.

Just as quickly as they had come, all of the nice feelings went away. Catra suddenly feels defensive. "Okay, thanks for telling me, I guess." Catra pushes her crush down her throat. Why would she care?

Adora's expression suddenly hardens, and she sits up on the bed, crossing her arms. "You know, I don't actually think dating is for me," she says loudly, her tone pointed.

Catra blinks at Adora's mood changr. "What, are you mad at me now?"

"No."

Catra knows this Adora. Just by the sudden change in the tone of her voice, Catra knows that Adora is trying to prove some point to herself, trying to articulate an emotion she is struggling to express into words. Unfortunately, right now, Catra has no idea what that emotion is.

"I'm too busy with school, and sports in the summer," Adora argues against herself. "A girlfriend will only be a distraction." Her words are clipped.

"Good for you, I guess. Glad you figured that out."

Adora's eyes flash. She opens her mouth, then closes it.

"What?" Catra sits up too, and stares the other girl down. She knows Adora is trying to get a reaction out of her. "Adora, what are you trying to say?"

Adora sits still for a second, a calculating look on her face.

"Adora-"

"I'm transferring to Bright Moon Academy next year!" Adora blurts. Her eyes widen, and she gasps, covering her mouth with her hands.

Catra stares at her best friend, feeling as if the floor has disappeared underneath her. Bright Moon Academy? How could she? Bright Moon Academy was full of private school snobs, and has been Horde High's main rival in both academics and athletics

for as long as the two schools have existed. Why would Adora choose them?

"What are you talking about?" Catra almost whispers.

"I accepted an athletic scholarship to Bright Moon Academy in April, for my senior year ." Adora says, her eyes shining. She brings her hands down from her mouth, and begins wringing them together. Adora is rambling. "Bright Moon is the best school to go to in hopes of being scouted by colleges and universities. They saw my potential, and gave me a scholarship and a place on their soccer team. That's why I've been so focused on sports and my grades this year, to keep up my average. That's why I go into school early everyday, so I can transfer my credits over. It's why I've been meeting with Coach before and after school. Catra, I'm sorry, I should have told you."

Catra is crying all of a sudden. She's never been a crier. She doesn't care. She can't believe Adora kept this secret from her. How could Adora leave me? What about all of the plans we have for senior year? Did they mean nothing to her?

"I lashed out, I'm so sorry Catra," Adora looks like she was about to cry too. She reaches over and grabs onto Catra's wrist. "I was upset, and I should have told you before, and I was being unfair."

Catra stares at her numbly.

Adora forces a smile. "And anyways, it's not like I'm moving towns. I'll still be down the block. I'll still be your best friend."

But that's not the point, Catra thinks. You'll forget all about me, just like you have been doing all semester. You'll have new friends, and I'll just be that girl down the block.

Wordlessly, Catra pulls her arm back, away from Adora. The other girl watches helplessly as Catra stands up robotically. Catra leaves.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> hi everyone sorry that it's been a while since i last updated! i am back now and let me just say hopefully it will all be worth it in the end 👀

Catra is done with wallowing.

Instead of falling into a pit of despair after leaving Adora's house that day, Catra studied. She worked hard. She put in the time and the effort. She joined Scorpia and Entrapta during their study sessions, and exams passed by like a breeze. Even physics, which she had been dreading, felt like nothing compared to what else was going in her life.

Exams are over. School is done for the year. Junior year was wrapped up. Summer is officially beginning.

And Catra feels hollow. It's like a piece of her was missing, ever since she walked out on Adora.

Adora.

Catra constantly finds herself trying to push away the hurt and the confusion and betrayal she feels when she thinks about her best friend. Or was it former best friend now? Catra wasn't sure. It's not like she disclosed the status of their relationship to Adora when she stormed out. It's not like Catra unfollowed Adora on all of their social medias. It's not like they had broken up, because they never even were together.

But yet, Catra can't help but miss her.

But Adora had lied to her, Catra has to keep reminding herself. Adora had avoided Catra all semester just to tell her that she was transferring to Bright Moon for their senior year.

But, really. Catra is done wallowing.

After spending the very first week of summer running around with Scorpia and Entrapta, Catra opens the front door to her house, exhausted, beach bag slung over her shoulder. She has just returned from the beach with them, Scorpia's moms having just dropped her off. Her bathing suit still feels damp underneath her shorts and t-shirt, and Catra can still feel the waves tugging at her feet from when she has waded into the water to appease Entrapta.

"Catra! How was it?" Catra's dad calls from the kitchen. "I've just started making dinner."

"Fine," Catra replies, taking off of her shoes and tucking them to the side. "Do you need help?"

"All good," he calls back. "You should go upstairs and change." Catra nods, and begins to make towards the stairs, beach bag in tow.

Catra's dad calls up right as she reached the first step, "Mara Grayskull called. Adora wants to talk to you." Catra ignores him and retreats to her bedroom.

Outside of Catra's window, the cicadas buzz and she can feel the heat of summer thick on her skin. She turns on the overhead fan, and watches it shudder to life. Feeling her tiredness deep in her bones, Catra collapses onto her bed, still in her beach clothes, exhaustion making her head foggy. Her phone lies discarded on the sheets.

Just as Catra was beginning to close her eyes, her phone buzzes from the beside her. It must be Entrapta, maybe she left something in my bag, Catra thinks, and grabs her phone, opening it. She squints against the harsh light. To her dismay, Adora's name flashes on her phone screen, this time, an Instagram Direct Message.

Adora's Direct Message reads, "Hey Catra. I'm sorry. Please text me back. I know you're getting these."

Catra scowls and shoves her phone under her pillow, leaving Adora on Seen.

Adora has sent Catra several texts since their that afternoon, and Catra always made the point to leave them read and unanswered, regardless of what social media platform Adora was reaching out to her on. Part of Catra knew it was petty, but she didn't even care anymore.

"What kind of friend even does that?" Scorpia had said when Catra had told her about the Adora Situation, as she now refers to it in her head. Scorpia has always been protective of Catra ever since Catra had her heart broken in sophomore year by some girl in her English class, and Catra is grateful for that protectiveness now more than ever. Scorpia has since redeemed herself from Adora's surprise appearance at the pool.

Catra's phone buzzes again. She checks it.

Another Direct Message from Adora: "Catra please I need to talk to you."

Adora doesn't deserve my time, Catra thinks. Not after she lied to me. Not after she blew me off all semester. Not after she ditched me for Bright Moon.

Catra, barely thinking, opens up Instagram and clicks on Adora's username. She scrolls down through Adora's countless pictures of team photos and selfies and sunsets to the most recent photo of the two of them. Posted in March. Has it really been that long? Catra can't help but wonder.

The photo of the two of them is a candid, taken by Catra's dad. They are in Catra's backyard, sitting in lawn chairs around the lit fire pit. Adora is mid-talking animatedly with her hands, and Catra was gazing, a dopey smile on her face. At the time, Catra had told Adora not to post it, since neither of them had been looking at the

camera. Adora had simply replied that it was her favourite picture of the two of them. Catra couldn't argue against that.

Catra, now looking at the photo months later in the darkness of her room, knows how gone she had looked, gazing at Adora in the photo. She might as well have had hearts for eyes.

She remembers growing up with Adora. Adora's mom teaching them how to ride bikes, Catra's dad taking them on camping trips. Catra remembers the countless sleepovers, the inside jokes, the holding hands underneath the table up until they were 10 years old. She misses Adora's stupid dorky laugh, the way she sticks her tongue out when she's concentrating. She misses the late night talks and casual banter. She misses the smell of Adora's signature vanilla-scented shampoo and how she always feels so safe around her. Hell, she even misses Adora's horrible driving. For as long as Catra knew, it was always the two of them. Catra and Adora.

Catra has it bad. Despite everything that Adora has kept from her, despite Adora lying to her for months, Catra still loves her. Maybe even more now, knowing that she could lose her.

And Adora doesn't love her back.

She wipes her eyes furiously, and hugs her knees to her chest. She lets the sound of the fan overhead lull her. Catra feels herself beginning to doze off.

Catra's dad calls her down for dinner, and she still hasn't changed out of her swimsuit and t-shirt and shorts.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> hi everyone! i want to apologize for the inconsistent chapter updates-my life had been so busy lately. but don't worry, this fic has always been sitting at the back of my mind, i have not forgotten it! anyways, i hope you enjoy, and if you want, please leave a comment! i love reading all of your comments, they really make my day.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra! DT invited us to their party this Saturday night!" Scorpia says excitedly over the phone.

Catra bites back a groan. She has never understood Scorpia's insistence on calling her every time she wanted to tell her something, instead of just sending a text.

Catra's start to the summer had gone by in a blur. Already, it was July. One month of ignoring Adora. Two weeks since Adora had figured out that Catra didn't want to talk to her anymore. One week since Scorpia had decided to become a socialite, apparently. And one month of Catra thinking nonstop about Adora.

"Okay?" Catra says.

"Okay?" Scorpia repeats. "Catra. Come on. It'll be fun. Entrapta already agreed to go with us."

"Who's us?"

"Please Catra!" Scorpia begs. Her voice softens as she says, "It might be nice, you know. Might take your mind off of, uh, you-know-who."

Catra couldn't argue against that. Despite trying to bottle her feelings away and put on a mask, Scorpia has always been able to

see right through her. Maybe getting out will do Catra some good.

“Fine.” Catra hangs up.

.

Catra, with permission, borrows her dad’s car, and drives to DT’s neighbourhood, half-listening to Scorpia and Entrapta’s excited chatter around her. The sky is darkening, and the light from the McMansions illuminate the street as Catra rolls into Elberon Drive. Cars already line the street, and Catra can see partygoers streaming into DT’s house.

“This is so exciting,” Scorpia breathes as she exits the car from the backseat, Entrapta stepping out from the passenger seat. Catra stays put, her hands clenching over the wheel. She feels anxiety prickling at her skin. Her earlier confidence has since disappeared. Catra had never been the biggest fan of parties, and it seems like the entirety of Etheria was at this party.

“This will be the best social experiment yet!” Entrapta chirps. “DT invited everyone. And by everyone, I mean everyone.” She pauses, looking back and forth between Catra and Scorpia’s faces. “I got the guest list.”

Scorpia turns to look at Catra through the car window. “Coming?” she says gently.

Catra takes a deep breathe, and carefully pries her hands off of the wheel. “Coming.”

Catra exits the car, locks it, and pockets her keys in her jacket. Catra suddenly feels self conscious of her outfit, a red jean jacket with black jeans and a white shirt. Scorpia has picked it out for her. The three make their way up to the front door, and Catra can hear the thump of the bass down in her feet from the too-loud music. *Wait, where those show tunes?*

“Deep breathes,” Entrapta instructs as she puts a hand on the doorknob. Catra does just so. Entrapta pulls open the door, and

the three of them are greeted with chaos.

Already, the house was trashed. Red solo cups and food and trash litter the floor, people that Catra knows and doesn't know moving around in a sea of colour before her. She feels her head begin to ache.

"Oh wow," Scorpia says from beside her. Catra agrees silently.

"Darlings!" DT crows from where they were chatting with Tung Lashor at the base of the staircase, right across from Catra and Scorpia and Entrapta. Catra hadn't noticed them immediately, and DT shoved themselves through the throng of partygoers to meet them. "So glad you could make it."

"Thank you for the invite!" Scorpia grins, seeming to have forgotten her nervousness.

"Relax, grab a drink, mingle," DT says, and gives Catra a pointed look. Catra scowls at them as they tilt their head back and laugh.

"Scorpia, my angel," DT says, turning to look at the other girl. "A certain someone is looking for you. Come with?"

Catra's ears prick with curiosity.

Scorpia looks between Catra and a Entrapta, as if asking for permission.

"Go on," Catra encourages. Just because she isn't having fun doesn't mean Scorpia has to.

Scorpia smiles gratefully at Catra and Entrapta. DT links their arms together and drags Scorpia off into the crowd of people.

"Are you hungry?" Entrapta asks Catra suddenly. "I hear there's tiny food in the dining room."

Catra smiles at her friend. "Let's go."

The two of them make their way over to the kitchen, avoiding a very queasy looking Mantenna as he makes a beeline to the bathroom near the front door, causing Catra to recoil with disgust.

"Tiny food!" Entrapta cries as they reach the dining room. The table is filled with little sliders, mini cupcakes, and other foods that Entrapta holds near and dear to her heart. She rushes over, and grabs a paper plate from the stack on the table.

"I'll be back," Catra tells her. "I'm going to the kitchen to get us a drink."

Entrapta nods in response as she fills her plate with one of everything.

Sighing, Catra steps out of the dining room and heads to the kitchen. She looks around at the party, taking everything in as she goes. She spots Grizzlor and Modulok having a food fight in the living room, Dylamug and Vultak egging then on. She sees Leech and Imp gossiping over on the couch, probably making fun of some poor kid in one of their classes from the previous semester, and then-

She sees Scorpia.

Scorpia is seated with a girl Catra does not recognize, tucked away in the corner of the living room. The girl is wearing flowers in her hair, and Scorpia seems delighted at every word that seems to leave her mouth. Their hands are clasped together. Catra watches them, transfixed. She feels an aching in her chest.

"Watch it!" comes a harsh voice. Catra, not paying attention to where she was going, had just bumped into a girl with purple hair, standing at 6 foot 3, all muscle.

"Huntara," Catra's mouth dries, as she looks up at the other girl. She has to crane her neck to look her in the eyes. "I'm sorry, I wasn't watching where I was going."

Huntara frowns. "Clearly not." She pauses, tilting her head slightly and giving Catra a once-over. "You're Catra, Adora's friend right?"

Catra's heart is beating in her throat. "Yeah. I guess."

"I remember seeing you at the games," Huntara says. "In the audience."

"That was me."

Huntara, seemingly satisfied, claps Catra on the shoulder. Catra jumps slightly.

"She's lucky to have you," the older girl says, and leaves. Huntara has never been known to be one with words. Nevertheless, Catra feels winded at what she had just said, and stumbles out of the kitchen. She curses at herself slightly when she realizes she forgot her and Entrapta's drinks, and turns around.

Suddenly, a commotion outside. Catra can just barely make out the sound of a splash through the glass doors that lead out to DT's backyard.

"Someone got pushed in the pool!" Kyle cries, running into the house through the glass doors. His hair is tousled and he has a wild look in his eye. "It looks like there was a fight!"

"This I gotta see!" Catra hears someone next to her say, and Catra finds herself being pushed out of the house by the throng of people trying to get to the pool. Catra stumbles out onto the grass, and finds herself right beside the pool.

A drenched girl crawls out of the water, fully clothed and shivering. A crowd of girls surround her, their eyes and teeth flashing as they loom over their victim, jeering at her. The victim coughs up pool water, and wrings out her hair, ignoring the cruel gazes and remarks. Catra hears the words "traitor", and "coward," and "Bright Moon" come out of the girls' mouths.

The drenched girl's hair is blonde.

Adora.

One month of ignoring Adora melts away. Catra acts on instinct.

"Oh my god, Adora!" Catra gasps, and rushes over to the shivering girl, completely ignoring the stares of the other partygoers "Are you alright?"

"I'm fine," Adora says through gritted teeth, shivering as she hugs her knees to her chest. The girls who pushed her in, who Catra now recognizes as Adora's soccer team, sneer at them and leave, heading back into the house. Catra senses the crowd around them is beginning to dissipate, seeing as there was no fight.

"You're not fine, you're drenched," Catra crouches down next to Adora. She shucks off her jacket and drapes it around Adora's shaking shoulders. "It's cool out. You could get sick like this. Let me drive you home."

"You don't need to do this," Adora shrugs off the jacket. "You just got here anyways. Don't worry about me, I'll get an Uber or something."

Catra doesn't question why Adora knows that she had just arrived at the party. "Don't be ridiculous. Come on, get up." Catra leads the shivering Adora back into the house, glaring at anyone who dare look at them funny.

Something small in Catra's brain is telling her to let Adora fend for herself, but she shoves it down as quickly as it had come up.

"Tell me what happened," Catra says as they get inside. She looks around cautiously, making sure that the team was gone, and leads Adora over to the bathroom, out of the way.

"I came with the team," Adora says quietly. "And they found out. About Bright Moon. They pushed me in."

Oh.

Catra just stares at her. Adora looks down at her feet, shoulders dropping.

"Catra? Adora? Is everything alright?" Scorpia asks in concern, rushing over to the bathroom, Entrapta hard on her heels. Catra can't help but notice that Scorpia is still holding hands with the flower girl.

"I need to get Adora home," Catra says, not wanting to explain any further. "I'm sorry. I can pay for your Uber-"

"I can drive Scorpia and Entrapta home," Flower Girl offers. "It's no worry."

Catra nods at her gratefully. She turns to Adora. "Let's go."

Adora nods numbly.

Saying goodbye to Scorpia and Entrapta and the flower girl, a Catra and Adora make their way to the front door. Catra feels her ears burn as people stare at them.

"Wait!" a voice calls. DT.

Catra turns, and sees DT come up to them, a towel in their hands. They give it to Adora. "Don't worry about returning this. I have plenty."

"Thank you," Adora says quietly.

DT tuts with sympathy. "Get home safely."

"We will," Catra says, and she and Adora leave. They head to Catra's car, and wordlessly get in. Catra starts the car and they pull out of DT's neighbourhood. The tension between them is thick enough to cut with a knife. Catra can hear Adora's teeth chattering.

"You didn't need to do this," Adora says softly from the passenger seat, breaking the minutes of silence. "Not after everything I put

you through."

Catra smiles ruefully, not taking her eyes off the road. "Adora, you were shoved into a pool. It's the least I can do."

Catra remembers she's supposed to be mad at her. Her hands grip the wheel a bit harder. Adora notices Catra's knuckles whiten.

"No, Catra, please listen to me," Adora turns to Catra, her eyes pleading. Her eyeliner has been smudged from the pool water, and have left grey streaks down her cheeks. "I need to tell you this."

"I think I've heard everything already," Catra says. They roll up in front of Adora's house and park, but Adora doesn't leave.

"Catra, please." Adora says. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry for not being a good friend. I'm sorry for hiding Bright Moon from you."

"Well, it's a little late for that."

Adora's eyes shine. "I know. It was wrong. I shouldn't have kept it from you."

"Probably shouldn't have kept it from your team, either." It was a low blow, and Adora flinches slightly. Catra immediately wishes she could take it back.

Adora takes a deep breath. "I'm sorry about Huntara."

"Huntara? What's she got to do with this?" Catra says in confusion. She turns to look directly at the girl in her passenger seat.

"I wanted to make you jealous," Adora whispers. "I'm sorry."

"Jealous? What are you talking about?"

"I've been so confused lately, and scared, and I made you suffer for it. I hate myself for doing that to you, Catra."

“Adora-”

Adora cuts her offs. “Can I kiss you?”

Catra doesn’t even hesitate. “Yes.”

Everything up until now had seemed to move too fast, too quickly, but now Catra was caught in slow motion. Adora leans towards Catra and gently brushes the hair out of her face. Adora’s eyes are so big and soft and blue as she searches Catra’s face. Adora puts her hand on Catra’s cheek, the other hand on Catra’s shoulder. Adora kisses her.

It’s soft and shy but it’s so, so sweet. Catra lets her eyes fall shut as she kisses back.

This is a bad idea, Catra thinks. She doesn’t care. She cups Adora’s jaw with her hand. It’s strong and stubborn underneath her touch, just like Adora. Catra has always loved Adora’s jaw.

Adora sighs against Catra’s mouth, and Catra can’t help but smile. It’s uncomfortable, with the gear shift poking into Catra’s ribs as she leans over to meet Adora’s touch, but she doesn’t care, because Adora is warm and alive next to her.

Adora breaks away suddenly. “I’m so sorry,” she says. “Thanks for the ride, Catra,” Adora doesn’t meet Catra’s eyes as she gets out of the car.

Catra watches helplessly as Adora trudges up to her house and opens up the front door, slamming it as it closes. Adora’s towel, once wrapped around her shoulders, now lies damp and crumpled on Catra’s passenger seat.

Chapter End Notes

feel free to check out my one shot the dog days are over!!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> hi everyone! i am so sorry for the long wait. school has been Very Busy and i have realized that i have neglected this fic for too long. thank you so much for your patience and for hanging on, i really appreciate it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Now it's Adora ignoring Catra's texts.

Catra lies in her bed, staring miserably up at her ceiling. The fan spins lazily above her, and Catra does not have the heart nor the energy to turn it off.

Adora had kissed her. Adora has asked Catra for permission, and Catra had said yes. Adora had kissed her, and then left her.

Catra wants to disappear.

She had slept fitfully last night, replaying the scene in the car with Adora over and over in her head. Now, having awoken, Catra remembers. She remembers the smell of Adora's shampoo, the way her hand had cupped her face. She remembers Adora next to her, solid and strong.

Now, Adora wasn't talking to her. Again.

Catra pulls her comforter up to her chin, hating herself for sending Adora all of those messages last night and this morning. As soon as Adora had shown her any attention, Catra lost all of her cool. She hates how Adora makes her melt in a way that no one ever has.

Catra feels like crying. She can see early morning sunlight stream into her room from her window, signifying the beautiful day ahead, but all Catra wants is to wallow.

Hurt and confusion tear at Catra's chest. *So, after all this time, Huntara was just a ploy? she can't help but wonder. Was Adora really trying to get her attention that way? Catra thinks of all the times Adora talked about Huntara, before and after they went out. She remembers when Adora would argue against herself, trying to make a point that she wasn't interested in dating Huntara.*

Catra hears her phone ping next to her head on her nightstand. She knows for a fact that it's Entrapta and Scorpia, wondering where she is and why she isn't responding to their messages and calls. She continues to ignore them.

As the day slips away, Catra can't help but stare at Adora's towel, lying discarded on the floor from where Catra had dropped it the night before. It's still damp, and has left a water stain on Catra's carpet. Catra's dad had tripped over it twice when he had tried unsuccessfully to coax her out of her bed earlier with a plate of cherries, sliced oranges and apples. When Catra didn't respond, he had left, leaving her with the plate of fruit and a sympathetic pat on her head.

Catra dozes in and out of sleep for the next few hours.

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She is suddenly awoken by two sharp knocks on her door, startling her. Catra sits upright in her bed, protectively drawing the covers closer to her chest. "Dad?" she calls.

Catra's dad opens the door, and to Catra's surprise, Scorpia and Entrapta are behind him. Catra's mouth falls open to protest, but her dad cuts her off.

"I let them in," Catra's dad says quickly, before Catra had a chance to speak. "They called the house, asking for you." Catra stares numbly as Scorpia and Entrapta shoulder past her dad and make their way over to her bed, Entrapta almost tripping over Adora's towel on the ground. Catra doesn't protest, and lowers the covers down to her lap.

"Dinner will be ready at 6:30," Catra's dad says, and closes the door behind him.

Catra scoots over in her bed to make room for both Scorpia and Entrapta to sit down. She feels grateful for their presence. The two sit, and exchange glances before addressing Catra.

"Catra, we've been texting and calling you all day," Scorpia begins gently. "Are you okay? What happened last night?"

"We're worried about you," Entrapta adds.

Catra buries her face in her hands. No use hiding it, she thinks, and lets out a groan, before she says, "IdroveAdorahomeandshetoldmeshewantedtomakemejealousbydatingHuntaraansthenshekissedmeandranout."

Scorpia and Entrapta look taken a back at Catra's word vomit. Catra groans again, and peers at them through her fingers, waiting for their reactions.

"She-kissed you?" Scorpia asks.

"Yeah," Catra says miserably. "She asked and I said yes and then she kissed me and ran out."

"Shit," Scorpia says.

"Has she said anything to you since?" Entrapta asks.

"No, she hasn't. She hasn't been responding to any of my texts," Catra replies.

"Do you think it's because her phone's waterlogged?" Entrapta suggests. "You know, from the pool."

Entrapta's suggestion seems so obvious that it's downright ridiculous. "I doubt it," Catra says bitterly. "It's not like this isn't the first time she's ignored me."

Scorpia puts a hand on Catra's shoulder. "I think you need to go over to her house and talk to her," she says.

"How?" Catra cries. "How can I even show my face? I don't think we can ever get past something like this. It's ruined."

"Catra, you have done nothing wrong," Scorpia says. "You need to talk to Adora. About everything. That is the only way you'll be able to sleep at night. Even if it is over, you need closure. Not knowing will eat you alive."

"You deserve it, Catra. After all you've been through." Entrapta agrees.

"Closure?" Catra echoes. Scorpia and Entrapta nod.

"You can't let this continue to haunt you. We hate seeing you like this." Entrapta says.

Scorpia adds, almost tentatively, "Especially when we know how much she means to you."

Catra closes her eyes. They're right. She needs closure. She needs to know why this has happened to her. It will kill her if she doesn't.

Catra almost felt dizzy, but she feels a fire begin to burn in her belly. She knows this has to be done. She knows she has to rip off the bandaid.

"Okay." Catra opens her eyes. She looks at Scorpia and Entrapta. "Okay. I'll do it. But first, please, let me get changed. As you can see, I'm still very much in my pyjamas right now."

Scorpia and Entrapta laugh.

.

After getting dressed, Catra bids Scorpia and Entrapta goodbye, watching them leave in Scorpia's mom's car, Catra goes to see her

dad in the kitchen, where he's been preparing their dinner. He smiles as she approaches him, pausing from chopping vegetables.

"I'm glad to see you up and dressed," he says.

"I'm going to talk to Adora," Catra says.

Her dad smiles at her softly. "I'm proud of you, Wildcat."

"Thank you," she replies quietly. Her eyes burn, tears threatening to spill.

"Good luck," her dad says. He checks the kitchen clock above Catra's head quickly. "It's 4:03. Don't worry about being late for dinner. I'll save you your meal."

"Thanks Dad," Catra says. She gives him a quick hug, and exits the kitchen. At the front door, she puts on her shoes, steps outside, takes a deep breath, and heads to the Greyskull's house.

Catra marches over to Adora's house with conviction. She has a whole speech planned in her head-she is going to confront Adora about how she had treated her this past year. The lies, the secrecy, all of it. She is going to tell Adora that she can't be waiting by the phone for her day and night. She is going to tell her that Adora can't just kiss her in her own car and leave.

Catra arrives at the Greyskull's house faster than she had anticipated. She catches herself hesitating at the base of the steps to the front porch, but quickly shakes her head and walks up. Before she could even take a deep breath and knock on the door, the door flies open, and she sees Adora, not looking at her and about to leave.

"Bye Mom, I'll be-" Adora calls behind her, and then jumps when she turns her head and sees Catra. Catra almost screams in shock. "Catra!"

“Adora? Everything okay?” Catra can hear Adora’s mom yell out to her.

“Everything is good, Mom!” Adora shouts back, her eyes not moving from Catra’s. Without looking, Adora closes the door behind her. The two girls stare at each other, both panting heavily from their almost-collision.

“Catra.” Adora breaks the silence. “You’re here.”

The initial shock has worn off, and Catra can feel anger that she had kept repressed for an entire year reach a boiling point. “Why haven’t you been answering my texts?” she demands. There goes her plan.

Adora looks startled. “I couldn’t. My phone got wet from the pool. It’s been in rice all day.”

Of course it has been. How did Catra forget? Entrapta had been right. The situation was so ridiculous that Catra couldn’t help but burst into a fit of laughter that she almost starts crying.

“Catra?” Adora asks with concern, reaching her arm out to her.

Catra wipes her tears. “You are such an idiot, you know.”

Adora’s gaze softens. “I know.”

Chapter End Notes

please forgive any spelling/grammatical errors! i’m posting this at 1:40 am and i will be sure to go back and edit!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

at last, we have made it to the end! i would like to thank everyone so much for their love and support, and your patience. thank you so much for sticking through with this story with me.
as a reward, i tagged in an epilogue after this chapter just to further show my gratitude to everyone who has read and supported my work. i cannot thank you enough!
also, i have created a fun little playlist if anyone is interested, which is inspired by this story and something fun to listen along to as you read. i hope you enjoy it!
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3ktqkZuG7zpAastbMLJQm6?si=WQVwakkdTEmBbtwvobe4mg

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“So,” Adora says nervously, “This is one stitch we got ourselves into.”

“You think?” Catra replies tiredly. She can feel all the fire that was in her chest quickly being extinguished, only to be replaced with aching tiredness.

Suddenly shy, Adora looks down at her feet, shifting back and forth. “I was, um, actually, I was on my way over. To see you.”

“Oh.” Catra can feel a lump beginning to rise in her throat.

“I owe it to you, to explain everything.” Adora says. She looks back up at Catra, her blue eyes wide and hopeful. “Take a drive with me?”

“Huh?”

“Take a drive with me,” Adora says, strongly this time. “Please. I owe you that Starbucks, from last time.”

Despite the heavy feeling that has settled in her chest, Catra bites back a laugh. “I’m going to order the most expensive drink on the menu,” she tells her.

Adora smiles. “I don’t doubt it.”

.

Catra sits nervously in Adora’s passenger seat, gripping on to her iced coffee for dear life as Adora pulls out of the Starbucks drive through. Internally, Catra kicks herself. How did I find myself stuck in this situation again? she wonders.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra catches Adora. The other girl’s eyes are scrunched in concentration, tongue sticking out between her teeth ever so slightly as she manages to avoid the curb while pulling onto the main road. Everything about it is just so Adora, at its purest form, and Catra feels herself melt a little. Dammit. After all this time, after everything that has happened, Catra is still so gone for her.

How did we get like this? she wonders tiredly.

“Where are we going?” Catra asks in a small voice.

“Around,” comes the reply.

“Your’e not going to kill me, right?”

“Ha, ha.”

Adora successfully pulls onto the main road, and they drive in silence through town. Catra can feel her heart beating in her chest. The last time she was in a car with Adora, they had-

No. Don’t think about it, she scolds herself.

Adora drums her fingers on the steering wheel, eyes focused on the road. Catra can't stop herself from admiring the slope of the other girl's nose, the grey of her eyes, the wisps of blonde hair that have escaped her ponytail and frame her face.

Catra winces.

"So," Catra says, clearing her throat. Her hands holding her iced coffee begin to shake a little. Afraid that it will spill, Catra carefully places it in the cup holder in front of her, in the centre console. "Are we gonna, are we gonna talk about what happened?"

Adora pauses her tapping and humming, and looks at Catra briefly, before turning her attention back to the road. Her face twists slightly, as if she was in pain.

"Yes," Adora replies. "Just, please, give me a moment. We're here."

In all of Catra's nervousness, she hadn't realized they had pulled into their old elementary school parking lot. The significance is not lost on Catra. She recognizes the dull cinder block walls, the painted red doors and the unwelcoming grey columns. She recognizes the place where she and Adora had become friends. The saying is true; sandbox love never dies.

The parking lot is empty, seeing as it is the summer, and Adora parks the car gracelessly against the chain fence, tucked away into the farthest corner of the lot. The two girls sit in silence. Catra can feel Adora breathing next to her.

"Why did you bring me here?" Catra finally asks, turning to look at Adora. To her surprise, Adora's shoulders have begun to shake. She was just as nervous as Catra was, she realizes.

"Catra, I-," Adora cleares her throat. "Catra, I don't know where to begin."

Catra stares at her. She has never seen Adora look this vulnerable before.

Adora begins to wring her hands nervously, and Catra can sense the word vomit before Adora even begins to talk. She can't seem to meet Catra's gaze.

"I am so sorry for everything that has happened this year. I've been a horrible friend to you, and I've been so cruel. I was trying so hard to fit in with my teammates, and the thing with Huntara just happened, and I just wanted to be brave for once, and I didn't realize that I was just lonely, and then I got the scholarship and I didn't know how you would react to that so I kept it a secret-."

"Lonely?" Catra can't help but gawk. "What do you mean, lonely? I was always there for you."

"No, not like that!" Adora cries, frantically waving her hands around. "I don't mean like that. I, I meant that I felt like I couldn't, I didn't want to-"

"Adora," Catra says. "Show down."

Adora takes a deep shuddering breath. "You're right. I'm sorry. Let me try again." she clears her throat, hiccuping slightly through her tears. "I didn't know how you would react to me leaving. I wanted to tell you, I really did, but I got selfish? We were in such a good place, well, I thought we were in such a good place, and I didn't want to ruin things and I thought that holding it off was the right choice, because I didn't want the fact that I was changing schools to ruin our summer."

"It wouldn't ruin our summer," Catra says. "We're neighbours. We're-" her voice catches in her throat slightly, "We are best friends. We will always find a way to see each other. I don't understand why you couldn't have just told me."

"I'm so sorry, you must think I'm the most selfish person in the world," Adora whispers. "I know I should've told you. Everything is just a mess, and it's all because of me. I feel so horrible. I am so sorry."

“Adora-”

“Please don’t feel any obligation to forgive me,” Adora continues. “I lied. I strung you along. I am so sorry. I wish I could take back everything that has happened.”

“I don’t,” Catra whispers, before she can stop herself. “Not everything.”

A beat.

Adora chokes back a sob. “What do you mean?”

“You know what I mean.”

Another beat.

“I-”, Adora pauses. She manages to look up to meet Catra’s gaze. “Do you mean, the kiss?”

Catra’s mouth feels like it is turning to sandpaper. “Yeah.”

“Me neither.”

“Then prove it.”

Catra closes her eyes. She expects to feel hands grab her shoulders. She expects to be pulled in, across the centre console. What she doesn’t expect is to feel Adora’s hand cup her cheek. Catra opens her eyes. Adora’s own gaze is filled with tears, streaming down her cheeks.

“Are you sure?” Adora whispers. “I don’t want this to be like last time. I am so sorry about last time. I didn’t mean to run away. I’m so sorry for running away.”

“Then don’t,” Catra breathes. With this, Adora closes the space between them.

Their lips press together softly, almost like a question. The kiss is small. It’s gentle. It’s them. Catra lets her eyelids flutter shit, and

sighs against Adora's mouth. Adora leans back, breaking the kiss, her left hand still cupping Catra's cheek.

"Is that okay?" Adora asks.

"More than okay," Catra replies.

Adora brings her other hand up to cup Catra's face, and leans in again. She kisses Catra's cheeks, her eyelids, her nose, the corner of her mouth. Catra breathes in her vanilla-scent, feeling her head beginning to swim.

"I am so sorry for everything," Adora murmurs in between kisses. "I want to make it up to you. All of it. Catra, I love you."

Catra gasps, as if lighting has struck her. She pulls back, staring into Adora's eyes.

"I love you," Adora continues. "I want you. I want to be with you. This whole thing, Bright Moon, Huntara- I was just trying to distract myself because I thought you didn't want me back. I want to hold hands with you in public and take you driving in my car and go to Red Lobster with you and have Double Trouble gossip about us to the whole school and I want to be around you all the time. I felt so lonely because I wanted you so badly, and you were right there, but I couldn't have you. But Catra, you are here. You are right here, right now. Catra, I love you."

Catra pulls back, but only so she can wrap her hands around Adora's. She is trembling again.

"You love me?" she whispers, hearing the shake in her voice.

Adora grips Catra's hands tightly, bringing them in towards her chest. "I love you," she says. "I always have. I'm so sorry it took me so long to tell you. And I'm so sorry for everything else, too."

"I love you too," Catra replies. Her heart is about to burst. "For all my life."

Adora lets out a sob and pulls her close. The gear shift jutting into Catra's stomach doesn't deter her as Catra holds her, pulling her in just as tightly. Adora buries her face into Catra's neck.

"I'm going to make it up to you," Adora says. "Every day. I will."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

Chapter End Notes

once again, thank you for all of your love and your support. it means the word to me!!
(also please forgive any grammatical errors i will go back and edit this as soon as i can! <3)

EPILOGUE

Chapter Summary

LATE AUGUST

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey, heads up!"

Catra squeaks as she is splashed with water as Scorpia dives into the pool. Drenched and irritated, she attempts to flick the water droplets out of her eyes as she can hear laughter around her. So much for lazing around poolside.

"Good form, Scorpia!" Entrapta calls from the shallow end, where she is currently testing out her new prototype submarines. Much bigger and larger and more waterproof from the last type, Entrapta had informed Catra.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra grumbles, standing up to walk over to the lawn chairs Scorpia's moms had laid out for them. She grabs her towel off of one of them and wraps it around her shoulders shivering.

"What's the point in coming to the pool if you don't want to swim?" Scorpia calls over to Catra, from where she has resurfaced down in the middle of the pool.

"Haven't you ever heard of suntanning?" Catra tries lamely, and Scorpia just tilts her head back and laughs.

"Catra!"

Catra can't help but perk up at the sound of her name. She turns around to see Adora walking through the wooden gate to Scorpia's backyard, two tall glasses of ice water in each hand.

Adora smiles at her, and quickens her pace to go stand next to Catra.

"Thanks," Catra says, taking a glass form Adora. Her girlfriend smiles, and leans in to press a kiss to Catra's shoulder.

Girlfriend. The word still makes Catra giddy.

The start of the new semester was fast approaching, the August skies preparing to turn to September. Catra welcomes the new season and she and Adora continue to explore this new relationship with each other together. New, exciting, and tumultuous at times, being with Adora for these past few weeks has made Catra feel so whole. Delighted with her friend's happiness, Scorpia had suggested that they should all get together for one more pool party before being dragged back to their studies. Of course, Catra obliged.

"Hey, why are you drenched?" Adora asks, poking at Catra's cheek.

Catra rolls her eyes in reply, swatting Adora's hand away playfully."Take a wild guess."

Adora laughs that wild laugh that Catra loves so much, and sits her down on the lawn chair. Aodra settles down next to Catra, wrapping her arms around her and resting her chin on Catra's shoulder. Catra shivers slightly at the feeling of the touch of Adora's touch, but enjoys it nonetheless. She leans back into her. If she was a cat, she's most certainly be purring.

"Get a room you two!" Scorpia calls over to them, getting a splashed by Entrapta in reply.

Adora looks at Catra. "Should we stick our tongues out at her?"

Ever the mature, Catra does exactly that, with Adora following suit. Scorpia laughs, causing Adora and Catra to crack up in return.

Leaning back into Adora, Catra sighs. “I’ll miss our drives to school everyday.”

“Me too,” Adora says, squeezing Catra tighter. Catra loves the feeling of Adora’s strong arms around her.

“Promise me you won’t forget about me at Bright Moon?” Catra teases. Adora only holds her tighter.

“I’m going to make this all up to you,” Adora says. “I promise.”

Catra smiles, turning her head to lean in closer into Aodra’s neck and breathing in the vanilla-scent of the other girl’s shampoo. The steady rise and fall of Adora’s chest against her back as she breathes calms her.

“Thank you,” Catra says.

Chapter End Notes

thank you everyone so much for your support, patience, and love. writing this story has been such a journey for me, and i am so glad you all were here with me. until next time! <3

End Notes

constructive criticism is always appreciated! come say hi to me over on tumblr at @ gfshera <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!